

NINA SCHOENER

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University of California, Berkeley
Department of Psychology

EDUCATION

Ph.D.	University of California, Berkeley Developmental Psychology Designated Emphasis in Cognitive Science <i>Primary Advisor:</i> Mahesh Srinivasan; <i>Secondary Advisor:</i> Silvia Bunge key topics: [word learning] [efficient communication] [cross-cultural differences] [semantics]	Fall 2023 – present
B.S.	University of California, San Diego Cognitive and Behavioral Neuroscience Minors in Psychology and Linguistics	June 2021
	Psychology & Neuroscience Study Abroad Program University of Maastricht, Limburg, Netherlands	Spring 2019

SCHOLARSHIPS, HONORS, AND AWARDS

Psychology Department Summer Research Fellowship, UCB	2026
Brains, Minds, and Machines Summer Course Travel Award, MIT	2025
Psychology Department Summer Research Fellowship, UCB	2025
Institute for Cognitive and Brain Sciences Grant, UCB	2024 – 2025
Zedeck Culture, Behavior and Management Study Award, UCB	2024 – 2025
Paula Menyuk Award, Boston University Conference on Language Development	2024
Bhattacharya Graduate Research Fellowship, UCB	2024 – 2025
Chancellor's Fellowship, UCB	2023 – 2025
Provost Honors, UCSD	FA17, FA18, FA20
Study Abroad Scholarship, UCSD	2019

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Ph.D. Candidate, University of California, Berkeley	August 2023 – present
Language & Cognitive Development Lab, PI Dr. Mahesh Srinivasan	
• Leading research on topics including: the value of various sources of information for word learning, the development of conceptual and semantic networks, and variation in children's learning strategies across cultural and linguistic backgrounds • Designing and running studies using naturalistic, experimental, and cross-cultural methodologies to assess children's potential to adapt to their language environments • Conducting computational analyses of language acquisition and use, including assessing communicative efficiency of developing and mature language use and evaluating Large Language Models trained on naturalistic child-directed data	

Lab Manager, University of Connecticut

July 2021 – July 2023

Communication and Development Lab, PI Dr. Sumarga Suanda

- Conducted research on mechanisms of partial learning of novel word meanings using an adapted Human Simulation Paradigm
- Designed and executed online cross-situational word learning studies to investigate the difficulties of early verb and relational concept acquisition
- Managed daily lab activities including overseeing several ongoing studies, planning research timelines, and mentoring a cohort of ~20 undergraduate research assistants

Head Research Assistant, University of California, San Diego

2019 – 2021

Language and Development Lab, PI Dr. David Barner

- Contributed to multiple projects related to transfer of early number concepts (e.g., cardinal principle) across languages in bilingual toddlers
- Oversaw and performed online and in-person data collection as part of a study on number Knower-Level and subitizing abilities
- Led a project investigating the reliability of the Give-a-Number task in bilingual toddlers by testing performance on the task over Zoom in both English and German

PUBLICATIONS & MANUSCRIPTS IN PREP.

Marchand, E., **Schoener, N.**, Sandoval-Franquez, J., Kendro, K., & Barner, D. (under review) Subitization in bilinguals: Evidence for language-specific mappings in number word learning.

Schoener, N., Johnson, S. C., & Suanda, S. H. (2025) Learning Partial Word Meanings from Referentially Ambiguous Naming Events. *Cognitive Science*.

Schoener, N., Johnson, S. C., Schoener, P., Suanda, S. H. (2023) Partial Word Learning from Referentially Ambiguous Naming Events: Evidence from a Human Simulation Paradigm. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, 45.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS AND INVITED TALKS

Schoener, N., Ortega Andrés, M., & Srinivasan, M., (2026, May 26). *Cross-linguistic transfer of informativeness biases in the kinship domain*. [Invited Talk]. HiTT Research Group of Theoretical Linguistics, University of the Basque Country.

Schoener, N., Ortega Andrés, M., & Srinivasan, M., (2026, April 9-11). *Navigating abstract semantic domains in a multilingual environment*. [Poster Presentation]. Cognitive Development Society, Montréal, Canada.

Schoener, N., Srinivasan, M., & Conwell, C. (2025, December 2-7). *Tracing the development of syntax and semantics in a model trained on child-directed speech and visual input*. [Poster Presentation]. NeurIPS CogInterp Workshop. San Diego, CA. United States.

- Schoener, N.,** Ortega Andrés, M., Zaslavsky, N., Regier, T., Srinivasan, M. (2025, November 6-9). *Do children's developing semantic systems maximize communicative efficiency? Evidence from children's acquisition of the Hindi kinship system.* [Conference Talk]. Boston University Conference on Language Development, Boston, MA. United States.
- Schoener, N.,** Ortega Andrés, M., & Srinivasan, M. (2025, July 30 – August 2). *Cross-linguistic transfer of informativeness biases in the kinship domain.* [Poster Presentation]. Cognitive Science Society, San Francisco, CA, United States.
- Schoener, N.,** Ortega Andrés, M., & Srinivasan, M. (2025, May 10). *Informativeness Biases in L2 Word Choice: Insights from Hindi-English Bilingual Children and the Kinship Domain.* [Poster Presentation]. Bay Area Developmental Symposium, UC Merced, CA, United States.
- Schoener, N. & Srinivasan, M.** (2024, November 8-10). *Children's Acquisition of Hindi Kinship Terms: A Study of Partial Word Knowledge.* [Conference Talk]. Boston University Conference on Language Development, Boston, MA, United States.
- Schoener, N., & Suanda, S. H.** (2024, July 24-27). *Partial Verb Learning via Observational Contexts* [Poster Presentation]. Cognitive Science Society, Rotterdam, Netherlands.
- Suanda, S. H., Boskovic, K., **Schoener, N.,** & Yang, M. (2024, May 20-23). *What Counts as Learning Matters: How Words are Learned in a Malevolent Referent World* [Poster Presentation]. IEEE International Conference on Development and Learning, Austin, TX, United States.
- Schoener, N., & Suanda, S. H.** (2024, March 21-23). *See What I Mean? Learning Verbs from their Observational Contexts* [Poster Presentation]. Cognitive Development Society, Pasadena, CA, United States.
- Yang, M.H., Williams, J.-A., Stoddard, B., **Schoener, N.,** & Suanda, S. H. (2024, March 21-23). *Acquiring Word Knowledge from Low Informative Input* [Poster Presentation]. Cognitive Development Society, Pasadena, CA, United States.
- Schoener, N.,** Johnson, S. C., Suanda, S. H., (2023, July 26-29). *Partial Learning of Word Meaning from Referentially Ambiguous Naming Events.* [Poster Presentation] Cognitive Science Society, Sydney, Australia.
- Schoener, N.,** Johnson, S. C., Suanda, S. H., (2023, March 23-25). *Partial Learning of Word Meaning from Referentially Ambiguous Naming Events.* [Poster Presentation] Society for Research in Child Development, Salt Lake City, UT, United States.
- Williams, J.-A., **Schoener, N.,** Stoddard, B., & Suanda, S. H. (2023, March 23-25). *Learning Words From Referentially Ambiguous Naming Events: Evidence from a New*

Artificial Word Learning Paradigm [Poster Presentation]. Society for Research in Child Development, Salt Lake City, UT, United States.

Suanda, S. H., **Schoener, N.**, Johnson, S. C. (2022, October 27-28). *Partial Learning of Word Meaning from Referentially Ambiguous Naming Events*. [Symposium Talk] AttLis, Storrs, CT, United States.

Schoener, N., Johnson, S. C., & Suanda, S.H. (2022, July 27-30). *How words can be learned by observation depends on what is meant by "learned"*. [Poster Presentation] Cognitive Science Society, Toronto, ON, Canada.

Schoener, N., Johnson, S. C., & Suanda, S. H. (2022, April 21-23). *How words can be learned by observation depends on what is meant by "learned"*. [Poster Presentation] Cognitive Development Society Biennial Conference, Madison, WI, United States.

Schoener, N., Marchand, E., Kendro, K., Barner, D. (2021, July 26-29). *Subitizing Abilities of Bilingual Subset-Knowers*. [Virtual Poster Presentation] Cognitive Science Society.

TEACHING

Graduate Student Instructor (UC Berkeley)

- **Psychology C146:** Language Acquisition (Spring 2024; Prof. Mahesh Srinivasan)
- **Psychology 1:** General Psychology (Fall 2025; Prof: Christopher Gade)
- **Psychology C123/Cognitive Science C131:** Computational Models of Cognition (Spring 2026; Prof: Anne Collins)

Reader (UC Berkeley)

- **Psychology 138:** Global Mental Health (Summer 2025)

OTHER EDUCATION & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

MIT Center for Brains, Minds, and Machines Summer School (August 2025)

University of Chicago Kinship Workshop and Summit; Talk: *Evidence of pressures towards communicative efficiency in developing semantic systems*. (January 2026)

MENTORSHIP & COMMUNITY SERVICE

Graduate Student Mentorship Program

Graduate Student Mentor, UCB Psychology, Fall 2025 – present

- Provided ongoing guidance to an incoming/first-year graduate student on research, advisor-advisee relationships, and graduate life

Quantitative Analysis & Coding Knowledge (QuACK) Workshop

Co-Organizer & Graduate Student Tutor, UCB Psychology, Fall 2024 – present

- Organized and led multiple workshops introducing first-year graduate students and summer research interns to data analysis and statistics in R
- Helped students prepare for their subsequent first semester of graduate-level statistics

Research Experience Pathways (REP) Program

Graduate Student Mentor, UCB Psychology, Spring 2024 – present

- Mentored multiple students from populations underrepresented in research (e.g., first-generation, nontraditional, ethnic & racial minority, or low-income backgrounds)
- Provided guidance on graduate school applications, career resources, and networking to each student for multiple semesters

Undergraduate Honors Thesis Students (UC Berkeley Psychology)

- Ayah Aldajani (2025)
- Caitlin Hubbs (2026)
- Kaylee Chavez (2026)

AFFILIATIONS

Cognitive Science Society (Member), 2019 – Present

Cognitive Development Society (Member), 2019 – Present

UCSD Cognitive Science Student Association (Member), 2018 – 2021

UCSD Psychology Club (Member), 2018 – 2021

SOFTWARE SKILLS

Programming: Python (PyTorch, Numpy, Pandas, Seaborn, Plotly), MATLAB

Statistics: R (Tidyverse), SPSS

Study Design: Gorilla, Qualtrics, PsychoPy, jsPsych, SMI Experiment Suite

Recruitment: Prolific, SONA Systems, FileMaker Pro, CloudResearch

Other: Datavyu

LANGUAGES

English: Native

German: Native

French: B2

Spanish: A2